HCI Foundations: D2

Navigating parents re-entering workforce after caregiving

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USER RESEARCH

Research Plan & Justification

- **Research Goal:** To explore parents' actual steps and barriers in re-entering the workforce.

- **Methodology:** Semi-structured Interviews (30 minutes per session).

- **Justification:**
  During our D1 Problem Space Analysis, we found a broad aspect of parents' career interruption after their caregiving through observation and contextual inquiry. However, we required more personal and lived experiences. Therefore, for D2, we planned semi-structured interviews to obtain both general and individual experiences. The research questions range from general to personal.

Introduction [~2 minutes]

Hi, my name is ____. Thank you for joining us today. We are grateful for your participation. We are working on a class project researching parents who plan to re-enter, or have re-entered, the workforce after taking a caregiving career break. We have prepared a 35-minute interview with 10 short questions.
Before we get started, would you mind if we record our session so we can reference it later? If you need to take a break at any time, feel free to let us know.

Main Questions {~25 minutes}

1. Can you describe what your previous job/industry was before you stepped away from the workforce, and how long your career break was for caregiving?
2. What are your motivations to start preparing to return back to work at this point in your life?
3. As you prepare to return to work, what do you feel are your greatest strengths? Conversely, do you experience any internal worries or anxiety regarding your current career gap or readiness?
4. Do you have people or resources in your life that support you as you prepare to return to work? What kind of support and how does it help you during?
5. As you prepare to return to work, what are your biggest concerns/challenges?
6. Can you walk me through your typical process for searching for a job, including what career platforms or resources you use and any frustrations or challenges you experience with them?
7. Beyond the job title and salary, what are some factors important to you when deciding whether a job is a good fit for your life right now?
8. Can you walk me through how you arrange caregiving when you need to do something related to your job search (e.g. interview, networking event, or training)?
9. Have you encountered any challenges related to caregiving or childcare during your job search or hiring process? If so, can you describe a specific experience?
10. If you could change one thing about the way career platforms support people returning to work after caregiving, what would you change?

Wrapping up {~2 minutes}

1. Is there anything I haven't asked you about today that you think would be valuable for me to know?
2. This has been very helpful. You've given me a lot of valuable insights for our team to think about as we continue to work on this project. Thank you for taking the time to talk with me.

USER RESEARCH

Participant Profile

We interviewed six parents who faced challenges re-entering the workforce after caregiving.



Participant 1

Working Mother

Age: 50s

Occupation: Office Administrator

> “Since I had never done office work before, adjusting to computer-related administrative and document work was highly anxiety-inducing at first.”



Participant 2

Working Father

Age: 30s

Occupation: Developer

> “Even when I'm working from home, I always have to be ready to switch between work and family — whether it's picking up my child or making lunch during my break.”



Participant 3

Founder

Age: 40s

Occupation: Entrepreneur

> “Caregiving is very isolating... I miss that feeling of being a part of something where a group of people try to do something that cannot be done alone.”



Participant 4

Job Seeker

Age: 40s

Occupation: Project Manager

> “When I applied for the job and somebody's going to call me back, like, ‘hey, are you ready to work?’ I feel panicked, to be honest.”



Participant 5

Working Mother

Age: 50s

Occupation: Retail Associate

> “I think organizations need to rethink how they view caregiving. It isn’t time off being unproductive; it’s caring for future generations one child at a time.”



Participant 6

Job Seeker

Age: 50s

Occupation: Job Seeker

> “Put yourself down as the ‘CEO of your household’ — which I find kind of disingenuous and misleading. It’s really hard for me to buy into that.”

USER RESEARCH

Open Coding

From Quotes to Codes

We reviewed transcripts and extracted insightful statements regarding user constraints, contextual barriers, and professional motivations.

Examples of codes

Unfamiliar work environment	Transitioning to a different field	Fear of new work
job searching stage is really hard	her schedule is very set	not moving fast enough
Competitive job market	Perceived impact of outsourcing and AI	Varying employer expectations for AI skills
Job searching as demanding work	Perceived lack of recruiter understanding	Concern about career re-entry in midlife
Limited regional job opportunities	Competition for remote positions	Difficulty explaining an extended career gap

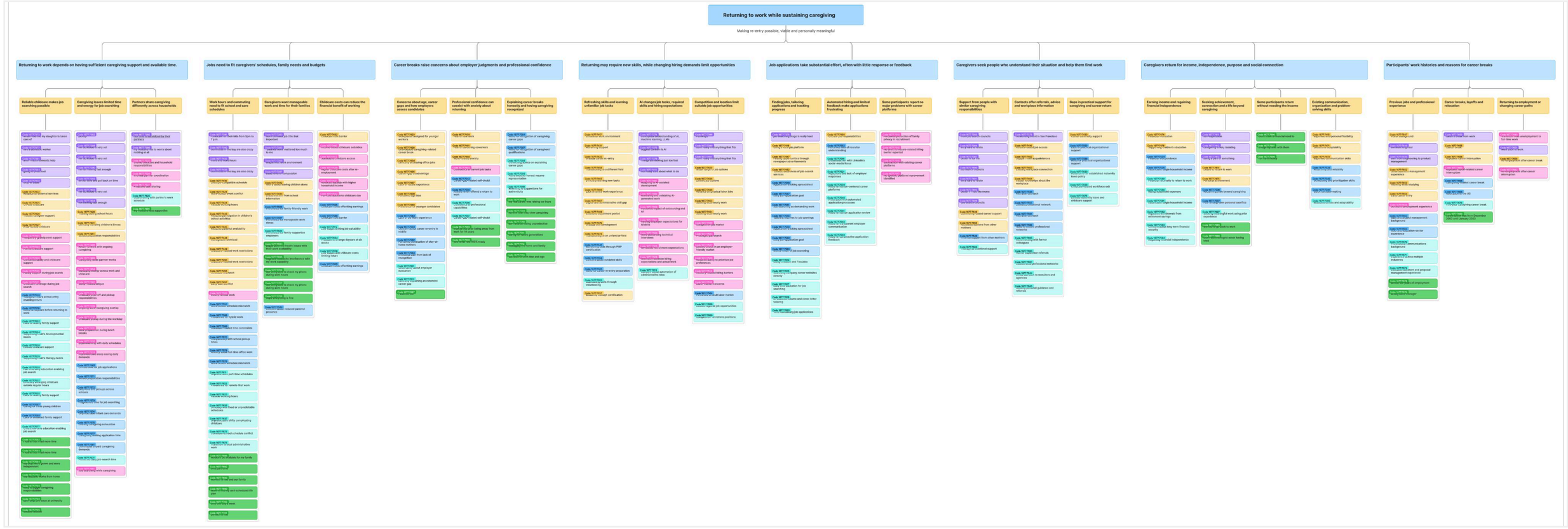
juggle potential health issues with their work availability	migraine headache interference with my work capability



USER RESEARCH

Affinity Mapping

We grouped related codes across interviews into themes, comparing shared experiences and differences among participants. These themes helped us identify key research findings about caregivers' return-to-work experiences.



RESEARCH FINDINGS

Finding 1: A job can match a caregiver’s skills but still be impractical for their daily life.

“That school schedule did not align with either my husband's or mine. [...] I could go work for $15 an hour at our local Walmart, but I can't control the schedule [...] and to find child care outside of that is also a huge part of the problem.”

Insights

Caregiving leaves limited time and energy for job searching

Reliable childcare makes job searching possible

Work hours and commuting need to fit school and care schedules

Childcare costs can reduce the financial benefit of working

Codes

`Ongoing work–caregiving overlap`

`Work-school event conflict`

`Childcare pickup during the workday`

`Managing energy across work and childcare`

`School preparation responsibilities`

`Childcare-related work restrictions`

RESEARCH FINDINGS

Finding 2: Career breaks can make caregivers feel uncertain about how employers will perceive their readiness to return to work.

“So trying to use my skills where I can. So hopefully when I do get an interview, I can talk about that career break and how maybe it wasn't just like a I did nothing with my time kind of a thing.”

Insights

Career breaks raise concerns about employer judgments and professional confidence

Professional confidence can coexist with anxiety about returning

Concerns about age, career gaps and how employers assess candidates

Codes

`Lack of recent experience`

`Confidence in professional capabilities`

`Career-gap-related self-doubt`

`Maintaining skills through volunteering`

`my real career was raising our boys`

RESEARCH FINDINGS

Finding 3: Caregivers invest significant effort in applications and explaining career breaks, often with little response or feedback.

"Just to apply to a single job can easily take up with like 45 minutes to an hour [...] it's also led to multiple rejections a week too, if anything at all [...] I wish [...] there would be more interaction and feedback in response to your application."

Insights

Job applications take substantial effort, often with little response or feedback

Explaining career breaks honestly and having caregiving recognized

Automated hiring and limited feedback make applications frustrating

Codes

`Need for constructive application feedback`

`Perceived lack of recruiter understanding`

`Daily job-application goal`

`Daily time allocation for job searching`

`Difficulty explaining an extended career gap`

`rethink how they view caregiving`

RESEARCH FINDINGS

Finding 4: Caregivers return for income, independence, and social connection, and value support from people who understand them.

“Now that I have the time, I want to focus on myself. Ultimately, my child won't need me forever—we all eventually seek independence from our parents. I want to build my own life and social connection outside of caregiving.”

Insights

Support from people with similar caregiving responsibilities

Seeking achievement, connection and a life beyond caregiving

Existing communication, organization and problem-solving skills

Codes

`Therapy as emotional support`

`caregiving is very isolating`

`Career continuity support`

`wanted to go back to work`

`Need to rebuild professional networks`

`Limited maternity leave and childcare support`

`self-expression`

HTA 1

Find & apply for a job opportunity

Task description

Parents returning to work search for job opportunities that fit their skills and family needs. They assess suitable roles, prepare application materials, and submit their applications.

Task characteristics

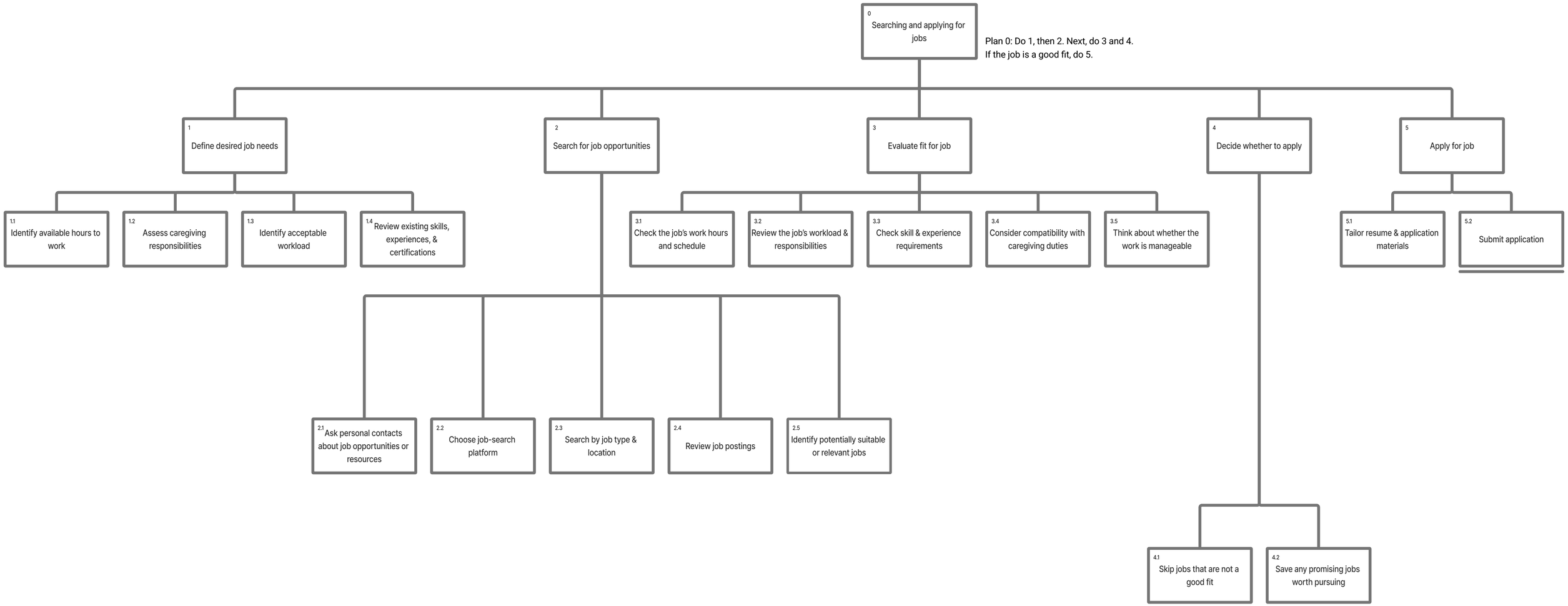
Parents browse job boards, update their resumes, and decide how to present and explain their career gap. They may feel uncertain about how employers will view the gap, especially when applications receive little feedback.

Task environment

The job search takes place alongside ongoing caregiving responsibilities. Parents often need to fit searching and applying into limited, unpredictable periods of free time.

HTA 1

Find & apply for a job opportunity



HTA 2

Preparing to return to work with caregiving responsibilities

Task description

This task considers how parents' caregiving responsibilities affect their preparation to return to work. Parents may need to arrange childcare and coordinate family responsibilities around potential work schedules while also preparing for conversations with employers.

Task characteristics

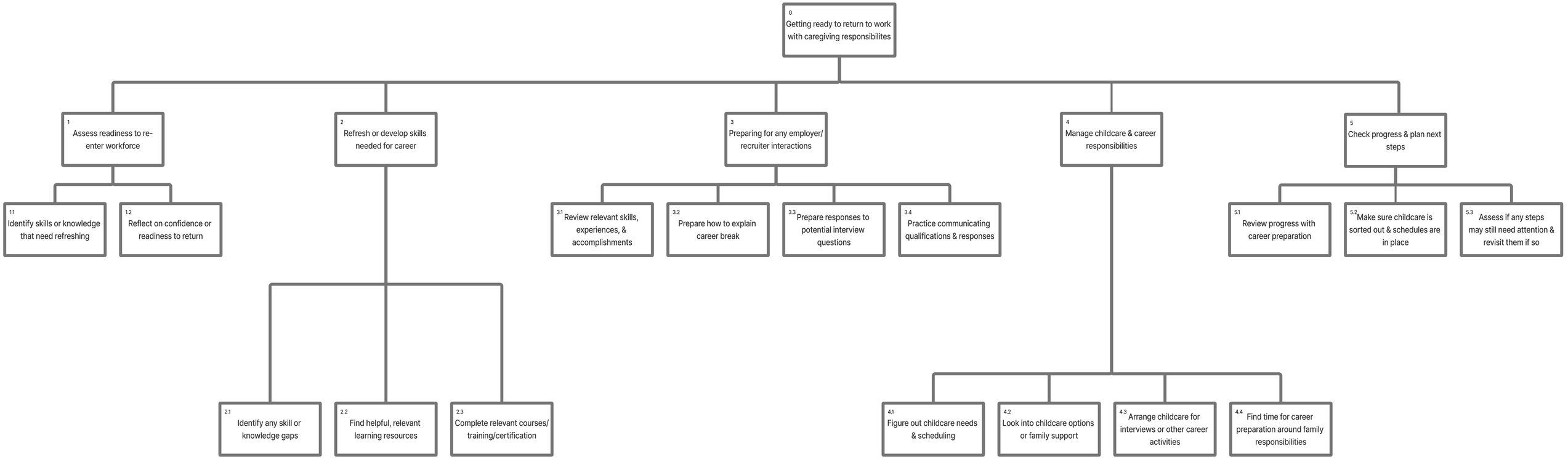
Parents need to find reliable childcare, develop skills for work, and explain their career gap and availability to employers. Balancing these preparations with ongoing caregiving responsibilities can be challenging.

Task environment

Parents may have limited time to prepare because of their caregiving responsibilities. Other factors include the availability and cost of childcare, support from family members, and whether employers offer flexible work schedules.

HTA 2

Preparing to return to work with caregiving responsibilities



DESIGN REQUIREMENT

Sensitizing Concepts

01

Accommodate diverse return-to-work goals

Caregivers return for various different personal, professional, and financial reasons. It's important to encompass the various reasons people return, since there is no single definition of success that reflects every caregiver's goals.

SUPPORTING EVIDENCE

D2 Finding 4: Caregivers return for income, independence, purpose, and social connection.

02

Seeing the person beyond the gap

Recruiters and hiring systems tend to focus on recent formal employment, which overlooks caregivers' capabilities they have developed or maintained during career breaks.

SUPPORTING EVIDENCE

D1: "If hiring systems are based primarily on chronological order, career breaks can easily be seen as having insufficient experience."(D1 Proposal, p. 17)

D2 Finding 2: Caregivers' existing abilities are not always reflected in their recent work experience.

DESIGN REQUIREMENT

Functional Abstractions

01

Support the assessment & coordination of return-to-work resources

Help caregivers assess and coordinate job opportunities, childcare, and career support to fit their daily responsibilities and return-to-work goals.

SUPPORTING EVIDENCE

D1: “organizations deeply care about providing services and offline events for parents, but these organizations’ **services and events are too fragmented**.” (D1 Proposal, p. 23)

D2 Finding 1: Jobs that match caregivers’ skills may still conflict with their daily responsibilities, highlighting the need to assess opportunities alongside available care support.

02

Translating caregiving into professional strengths

The design should help caregivers identify and communicate relevant strengths from prior work, learning, and caregiving experiences they choose to share, connecting concrete examples to their target roles.

SUPPORTING EVIDENCE

D1: “better accommodate nonlinear career paths and **rethink how they present and interpret career experiences**”(D1 Proposal, p. 17)

D2 Finding 2: Career breaks can make caregivers feel uncertain about how employers will perceive their readiness to return to work.

DESIGN REQUIREMENT

Prescriptions

01

Clarify job expectations upfront

Our design should provide filters for remote/part-time/flexible job positions so caregivers can quickly know if a role fits their needs and minimize time spent assessing if it does. It should also clearly display working hours, location requirements, and the specific conditions of flexibility before they start investing time in applying.

SUPPORTING EVIDENCE

D1: Existing career **tools are limited to superficial filters** like "remote" or "part-time" instead of supporting a flexible return-to-work pace.
(D1 Proposal, p. 28)

D2 Finding 1: shows that a role can match a parent's skills while conflicting with their daily life.

02

Peer parent and community support connections

The design should provide moderated connections with peers and mentors who share relevant caregiving situations, career goals, or return-to-work experiences.

SUPPORTING EVIDENCE

D1: “Taking time away from work can present obstacles in maintaining professional networks since access to major networks and mentoring relationships starts vanishing for women who have left the workforce (Cabrera, 2007).”

D2 Finding 4: Caregivers value practical support from people who understand their circumstances and want to rebuild social and professional connections.

Cabrera, E. F. (2007). Opting out and opting in: Understanding the complexities of women’s career transitions. *Career Development International, 12*(3), 218–237. https://doi.org/10.1108/13620430710745872

Measuring Success (Functional Requirements)

Requirement	Measure of success	Metrics to measure
Support the assessment & coordination of return-to-work resources	Using task-based usability testing to assess if caregivers can identify resources that fit their needs (e.g. job goals & caregiving responsibilities)	• Task completion rate • Time spent on task • Number of navigation errors • Participant's rated usefulness of the plan
Translating caregiving into professional strengths	Evaluating their experience with identifying their relevant skills and communicating them through examples	• Task completion rate • Relevance of identified skills to target roles • Number of relevant skills that were identified • Participant's confidence ratings
Clarify job expectations upfront	Test if caregivers can quickly find suitable positions & be able to accurately explain their working hours, flexibility, and location before officially applying	• Task completion rate • Time to find suitable job • Accuracy of the job requirement comprehension • Number of clicks/navigation steps
Peer parent and community support connections	Evaluate if caregivers can find peers/mentors for their needs and what resources/advice they received through it	• Task completion rate • Time to find a suitable peer/mentor • Survey questions (Rating usefulness of resources & ratings for suggested connections)

Measuring Success (Non-Functional Requirements)

Requirement	Measure of success	Metrics to measure
Accommodate diverse return-to-work goals	Test the design with caregivers who have various different personal, professional, and financial goals and reasons for returning to work. Then, evaluating if they can find options that align with their specific needs	• Task completion rate • Count and types of participants' goals (personal, professional, and/or financial) • Time spent on task • Number of errors (with navigation) • Participant's rated usefulness of the plan
See the person beyond the gap	Ask caregivers if the design helps them recognize their capabilities and communicate them without feeling that their caregiving break has tainted their professional capabilities	• Count of transferable strengths identified • Participant's confidence rating in communicating their skills • Survey questions (e.g. agreement data with statements like "This design represents my capabilities fairly") • Qualitative feedback if caregivers think their skills/experiences are fairly represented